> suggests that the Scali and Feklisov discussion of the next day may well have been a peace feeler initiated by Khrushchev or someone close to him once the Praesidium had set the new line. The similarity of the language of this decision and Feklisov's language on October 26 seems too strong to be merely a matter of coincidence.[36]

Yet, this new (or old) interpretation does not account for Feklisov's continuing insistence that he did not propose to Scali what Scali conveyed to the State Department. Indeed, in his memoir, Feklisov recounts that when, at the 1989 Moscow conference, he disavowed his purported role, there was hostility toward him from senior officials.[37] For the KGB, the suggestion that one of their officers helped resolve the crisis (and save the world) was surely attractive. There is an axiom that no one comes out badly from their own memoir. Yet, here, Aleksandr Feklisov was willing to forego the sobriquet of 'The Spy Who Saved the World'. Instead, he maintained: 'I have no right to take the credit they want to force on me.'[38]

What of the lunch itself? According to Feklisov, Scali ordered a vegetable salad as a starter, while he opted for a Manhattan clam chowder.[39] They each had a martini. When the food was brought, Scali took the soup instead of the salad. Both had steak and potatoes for the main. Neither seems to have considered a pudding. According to Michael Dobbs, however, they ate pork chop (which Feklisov ordered and Scali ate) and crab cakes (which Scali ordered and Feklisov ate).[40] 'The Pork Chop That May Have Saved the World,' is how another writer, Emily Robinson, describes it.[41] If the historical record cannot find agreement on this sort of detail, it is surely clear that, when writing history, there is no such thing as a free lunch.

One other intriguing episode – revealed by Fursenko and Naftali in their 1997 book – concerns events at the National Press Club in Washington, late on Thursday, 25 October. Johnny Prokov, a Russian émigré who worked there as a barman, overheard a late-night conversation between two journalists on the *New York Herald Tribune*, Robert Donovan and Warren Rogers. With American forces preparing for an invasion of Cuba, US